

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 3

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young pianist describes the minutes before a competition final, the walk on stage, and the moment of the first chord.

1

The wings of the concert hall smelled of old wood and floor polish, and behind the heavy black curtain my fingers had begun, very politely, to betray me. They were not shaking exactly — that would have been honest — but a strange, cool tremor ran from my wrists to my fingertips, the kind of tremor one feels in a piece of metal just before it snaps. I tucked my hands under my arms, the way my mother had taught me to do when I was eight, and tried not to think about the eight hundred faces on the other side of that curtain.

2

My mother stood at the edge of the wings as she always did, half in shadow, half in the warm orange spill of the stage lights. She did not speak. She had stopped speaking to me on the morning of competitions when I was twelve, after I told her, quite sincerely, that her good wishes felt heavier than my own nerves. Tonight she only watched me with that careful, unreadable face — the face of a woman who has spent twenty years driving a child to lessons, and who knows better than to interfere in the last five minutes. I loved her, suddenly and inconveniently, more than I could afford to love anyone just then.

3

The previous competitor finished. Applause swelled, broke against the curtain, and rolled away. I heard the stage manager's whisper, dry as turning paper: "You're up." For a moment I could not feel my feet. Then my mother, without taking her eyes off the score in my hand, reached out and pressed her thumb, very lightly, against the inside of my wrist. It was the smallest gesture in the world. It was the only one I needed.

4

I walked. The stage, which had looked so manageable in rehearsal, had grown overnight into a vast lit plain, and the piano at its centre had become a small black animal waiting to be approached. I bowed.

The audience was an ocean of pale ovals, indistinguishable and patient. I sat. The bench was a fraction too high; I adjusted it with hands that I no longer entirely owned. I lifted the score, opened it to the first page, and then, mercifully, closed my eyes for a count of three.

5

In the dark behind my eyelids, the practice room reappeared: the chipped piano stool, the metronome with its sticky catch, the long afternoons of scales that had bored me to tears at twelve and saved me at sixteen. My teacher's voice was there too, calm and slightly nasal, repeating the sentence she had taught me to whisper before every performance: **The fear is information, not an instruction.** I did not, in that moment, entirely believe her. But I trusted her, which is a different thing, and trust, on a concert stage, is often enough.

6

I opened my eyes. I lifted my hands. The hall, which had been holding its breath, leaned forward an inch. And then I struck the first chord.

7

The sound bloomed outward — full, certain, slightly warmer in the bass than I had expected — and something in me unclenched so completely that I almost laughed aloud. The fear did not vanish. It moved aside. It stood in the wings now, with my mother, watching me work. The rest of the piece, when I think of it now, is not a memory so much as a long bright corridor that I walked down without stopping, the keys offering themselves up to my hands one after the other, as though they had been waiting, all this time, to be played.

8

I did not win the competition. A boy from Seoul, two years younger and twice as fearless, took the first prize, and I stood politely with the others while his name was announced. But when I came off the stage and found my mother in the wings, she did not say “well done”, and she did not say “next year”. She only nodded once, the way she had nodded at me when I was four and had finally, after a long battle, tied my own shoelaces. It was, I think, the proudest sound her face had ever made.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says her fingers had begun “very politely, to betray me.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about how her nerves were affecting her. [2]

2. The narrator compares the tremor in her fingers to “a piece of metal just before it snaps.” Explain how this comparison helps the reader understand the narrator's state of mind. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator's mother is described as “half in shadow, half in the warm orange spill of the stage lights.” Give **two** ways in which this description suggests her role in the narrator's life. [2]

4. The narrator says she loved her mother “suddenly and inconveniently.” What does the word **inconveniently** tell us about the narrator's situation at that moment? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The stage manager's whisper is described as “dry as turning paper.”
- (a) What does this comparison suggest about the stage manager's tone? [1]
- (b) Why is this detail effective at this point in the narrative? [1]

6. The narrator says her mother’s thumb on her wrist “was the smallest gesture in the world. It was the only one I needed.” Explain how the language used here emphasises the **importance** of this small gesture. [2]

From Paragraph 4

7. In Paragraph 4 the narrator says the piano “had become a small black animal waiting to be approached.” Explain how this image affects the reader’s view of the piano. [2]

8. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 4 that the narrator’s body was no longer fully under her own control. [1]

From Paragraph 5

9. The narrator recalls her teacher’s saying: “The fear is information, not an instruction.” In your own words, explain what this sentence means. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator says that, after the first chord, the fear “did not vanish. It moved aside.” What does this suggest about how the narrator’s relationship with her fear changed once she began to play? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article weighing the arguments for and against the four-day working week.

1

For most of the last century, the five-day working week was treated as a settled fact, as fixed and natural as the seven-day calendar to which it was attached. That assumption is now under strain. From Reykjavik to Wellington, governments, unions and individual companies have begun to test the proposition that paid work might reasonably be compressed into four days a week, with no loss of salary, on the understanding that workers will produce as much — or, more provocatively, **more** — than they did over five. The idea, once dismissed as the dreamy property of leftist think tanks, is now the subject of serious pilots, serious data, and increasingly serious arguments.

2

The Icelandic trials of 2015 to 2019 are usually cited as the founding evidence. Run jointly by Reykjavik City Council and the national government, they covered some 2,500 workers — about one per cent of the country's workforce — across schools, offices, hospitals and social services. Workers moved from 40 hours a week to 35 or 36, with no cut in pay. Productivity, measured by output and service-delivery indicators, either held steady or improved. Researchers concluded, cautiously but firmly, that the experiment had been “an overwhelming success”, and Icelandic unions have since negotiated shorter hours for roughly 86 per cent of the country's working population.

3

The United Kingdom trial of 2022 produced a similar verdict on a smaller stage. Sixty-one companies, ranging from a fish-and-chip shop in Norfolk to a London-based software firm, gave 2,900 employees a paid day off each week for six months. At the end of the trial, 92 per cent of the participating companies said they would keep the new schedule. Revenue, on average, rose by 1.4 per cent. Resignations dropped by 57 per cent. Employees reported sharp falls in stress, burnout and sleep difficulties, and modest but consistent improvements in family life and exercise. These are not the numbers, supporters argue, of a workforce coasting through a long weekend.

4

The theoretical case for compressing the week rests on a simple observation: hours worked and work actually done are not the same thing. A person paid to sit at a desk for eight hours does not, in practice, deliver eight hours of focused output; somewhere between the inbox, the standing meeting and the third coffee, a great deal of the day is quietly lost. The four-day week, advocates argue, forces organisations to identify and remove this slack — to shorten meetings, automate routine tasks, and trust employees to manage their own time. The result, they claim, is not less work but better work: rested staff, sharper decisions, lower turnover.

5

Employers, however, have not been universally persuaded. Some object on principle: a contract for five days, they argue, should be honoured for five days, and the question of how the time is filled is not for the employee to renegotiate. Others worry, more practically, that the pilots so far have been heavily weighted towards knowledge work, where output is measured in projects rather than minutes. What, they ask, would a four-day week look like in a hospital ward, a fire station, or a 24-hour port? In sectors where the work is, by its nature, the presence of a human body in a particular place, compressing the week without cutting service is not a matter of trimming meetings. It requires either additional hiring, additional overtime, or genuinely fewer hours of cover — none of which is free.

6

There are also harder questions about who benefits. Office workers with school-age children may welcome

a Friday at home; shift workers in retail and care, whose contracts are already hourly and precarious, may find that “a four-day week” simply becomes an excuse to compress their hours into longer, more punishing days. Critics have pointed out that several high-profile pilots have quietly excluded the lowest-paid sectors of the economy, and that without strong protections, the policy risks becoming, in practice, a perk for the salaried middle class and a burden for everyone else.

7

Where, then, does this leave us? Probably not at a single, tidy answer. The four-day week is unlikely to be a universal law any time soon, but the wider conversation it has opened — about what we actually owe our employers, what they actually owe us, and what counts as a fair day’s work in an age of laptops and notifications — is unlikely to close again. Even those who reject the four-day model now concede that the old assumption, that more hours always means more output, is no longer respectable. What replaces it, sector by sector and country by country, will define the shape of working life for at least a generation.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says the five-day week was once treated as “a settled fact, as fixed and natural as the seven-day calendar.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about people’s **attitude** to the five-day week in the past. [2]

13. The writer says the idea was once dismissed as “the dreamy property of leftist think tanks.” What does this phrase suggest about how the idea was **originally received**? [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** pieces of evidence that the Icelandic trial was considered a success. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer ends Paragraph 3 by saying, “These are not the numbers, supporters argue, of a workforce coasting through a long weekend.” What is the writer’s **purpose** in including this sentence? [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. The writer says that “hours worked and work actually done are not the same thing.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

17. According to Paragraph 4, give **two** ways in which a four-day week is said to improve the quality of work. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer asks: “What ... would a four-day week look like in a hospital ward, a fire station, or a 24-hour port?” Explain why the writer lists these three workplaces in particular. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer puts the phrase “a four-day week” in inverted commas in Paragraph 6. Why? [1]

20. The writer says the policy risks becoming “a perk for the salaried middle class and a burden for everyone else.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer concludes that the old idea — “that more hours always means more output” — is “no longer respectable.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the benefits of the four-day working week** and **the limitations or objections it faces**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Supporters of the four-day working week claim that ...

— END OF PAPER —